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FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Marketing Forward

Date & time: Oct. 15, 10:00-10:35 AM
Track: Strategic AI



Mitch Joel

Executive Director, Next Era Institute

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Session Description

Marketing is undergoing its most profound shift since digital began. We're moving out of The Attention Economy - defined by reach, noise, and volume - into The Intimacy Economy shaped by relevance, connection, and meaning. The old one-to-many model can't keep pace with consumers who now expect brands to understand them and adapt in real time.

With AI, we're entering a one-to-X world: the ability to communicate at scale with nuance, context, and personalization that once seemed impossible. This session shows leaders how to escape the cycle of "more content, more channels, more speed" and shift toward momentum, clear direction, smarter decision-making, and marketing systems built to thrive in an age of constant acceleration.

Drawing on the proprietary P.A.C.E. framework, Marketing Forward redefines what modern marketing must become: intelligent, empathetic, and deeply human. You'll learn how AI will reshape creativity and storytelling, why intimacy is the new competitive advantage, and how to design teams and brand experiences that create value that compounds instead of content that disappears.

This is the blueprint for marketing's next chapter… deeper, smarter, and built for leaders ready to rethink what truly connects.

Key Quote

> *"AI will not kill marketing; it's going to kill your excuses for why you can and cannot build engagement, audiences, activity, and motion."* **- Mitch Joel**

Session Summary

Mitch Joel, Executive Director of the Next Era Institute, delivered Marketing Forward, a session on how marketers should show up as AI reshapes the industry. He opened with a story about ordering a milkshake through the McDonald's app at the Montreal International Jazz Festival, where a broken machine and a manager who told him "the app is not us" stood in sharp contrast to an article calling McDonald's the new operating system for global retail. His point was that, after decades of digital transformation and several years of generative AI, customers and employees still aren't feeling the promise of the technology.

Joel argued that disruption is no longer an event but the operating system we all live in, and that employees are adopting AI faster than their organizations can transform. His provocation was that "speed is dead": not something to ignore, but something to accept rather than use as an excuse. Building on a line from Paulo Coelho, he offered his own equation, "Direction and momentum is greater than speed."

He then described a "tale of two cities." In the intelligent city, AI is about personalization for customers and making internal teams better; rather than replacing marketers, AI is exposing them, revealing both weaknesses and opportunity. In the intimate city, drawing on Yuval Noah Harari's idea of a shift from the attention economy to the intimacy economy, Joel described a "one to X" moment where brands can use AI to connect with people in deeply personal ways, much like a For You feed that seems to know you. He cautioned against "automating the life out of marketing," and noted that as AI agents start shopping, the new B2B must also be "brain to brain."

To help leaders pace themselves, Joel introduced the P.A.C.E. framework: Palette (broadening creative, strategic, and technological skills, with taste as a practice), Agency, which he is reframing as ambition, Commune (coming together in person and building community), and Elevate and Educate (continually raising the bar). He illustrated these with examples including Five Below, Poppi, Whatnot, Shopify, and Cisco, which gave 90,000 employees their own agents while requiring them to set objectives, supervise each step, and remain accountable.

He closed by urging the audience not to "lobotomize marketing" and to be just 1% more curious than afraid. Using the analogy of the abacus and the calculator, he challenged marketers to become power users of the new tools rather than be left behind by them.

Key Takeaways

- **Direction beats speed:** Accept that change will always feel fast, and focus on the equation that direction and momentum are greater than speed.
- **AI exposes, not replaces:** Rather than replacing marketers, AI is exposing how teams operate and showing where the real opportunity lies.
- **Compete in the intimacy economy:** Use AI to move to a one-to-X model where customers feel a brand truly understands them on a personal level.
- **Don't automate the life out of marketing:** Let AI handle the friction while marketers create the meaning, because trust and relevance remain the future of marketing.
- **Pace yourself with P.A.C.E.:** Build your palette, act with agency and ambition, commune with others, and keep elevating and educating yourself and your team.
- **Pair AI with accountability:** Like Cisco, give people agents but have them set objectives, supervise the work, and own what they do with the time they gain.